

three years in a row between 1989 and 1991. The fanfare around this year's win was amplified by another historic achievement: NorthEast became the first team in the post-Independence era of the 137-year-old tournament to win a final by such a commanding scoreline. The previous best had come back in 2001, when the now-defunct Mahindra United beat Churchill Brothers 5-0. For NorthEast United, the triumph carried extra weight; it had taken the franchise nearly a decade to win its first national-level silverware when it edged Mohun Bagan in penalties last year.

**This time, it not only defended the title but did so in emphatic style, underlining its growth as a team.** The joy was reflected in the reaction of its owner, Bollywood actor John Abraham, who celebrated each goal by congratulating the dignitaries in the VIP box before joining the players after full time. In true celluloid fashion, he led the squad to the stands to share the moment with fans, ensuring that the revelry stretched late into the night.

If the celebrations highlighted the occasion, the team's performance across the tournament justified it. NorthEast United looked the best-prepared side in the competition, sharper and fitter than most of its Indian Super League rivals — Mohun Bagan SG, Emami East Bengal, and Jamshedpur FC included — even though it had only begun pre-season a fortnight before the Durand. Much of the credit lay with coach Juan Pedro Benali, who assembled a balanced squad of Indian and foreign players and instilled a clear structure. The Highlanders went through the tournament unbeaten, the only stumble being a 2-2 draw against I-League 2 club Rangdajied United in the group stage. That match proved a timely wake-up call, as the team regrouped and powered through the

quarterfinals and semifinals before turning the final into a one-sided affair. For Diamond Harbour FC, though, the tournament itself was a breakthrough.

**Making its Durand Cup debut, the I-League Division 2 champion turned plenty of heads with its spirited run under Spanish coach Kibu Vicuña.**

Placed in a tough group that included ISL double winner Mohun Bagan SG, the three-year-old club still advanced as one of the two best runners-up — alongside Shillong Lajong — thanks to wins over Mohammedan Sporting and seven-time champion Border Security Force. With five teams locked on six points, Diamond Harbour's superior goal difference proved decisive.

From there, the fairy tale gathered momentum. In the quarterfinals, Diamond Harbour stunned Jamshedpur FC 2-0, before eliminating East Bengal 2-1 in the semifinals. That result carried special weight, as East Bengal had been widely tipped to take the trophy after its derby win against Mohun Bagan in the quarters. For a side that was barely three years old, to reach the final by beating established giants was an achievement in itself.

Had Diamond Harbour pulled off one more upset, the Durand Cup would have crowned another debutant champion, following in the footsteps of Gokulam Kerala in 2019 and FC Goa in 2021. But NorthEast United had other ideas. The defending champion held firm, and with a performance as ruthless as it was historic, gave fresh meaning to its place in the annals of Asia's oldest football tournament.

**Creative spark:** Alaaeddine Ajaraie lit up the final, finishing with four assists and a goal in a dazzling all-round display. DURAND CUP MEDIA



## Roll of honour

### INDIVIDUAL AWARDS

**Golden ball (player of the tournament):** Alaaeddine Ajaraie (NorthEast United FC)

**Golden boot (highest goal scorer):** Alaaeddine Ajaraie (8 goals)

**Golden glove (best goalkeeper):** Gurmeet Singh (NorthEast United)

### TEAM PRIZES

**Champion:** Rs. 1.21 crore (40% of pool)

**Runner-up:** Rs. 60 lakh (20%)

**Losing semifinalists:** Rs. 25 lakh each (8.3%)

**Losing quarterfinalists:** Rs. 15 lakh each (5%)

**Individual Awards:** Golden Ball, Golden Boot and Golden Glove winners received Rs. 3 lakh each, plus a brand-new Mahindra XUV 3XO each.

